



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 5

CALIFORNIA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside California's family courts and child-welfare system.

193

CALIFORNIA FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
240 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 2 MONTHS
MEDIAN TIME IN SYSTEM

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 25, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
10 OF 58

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

CALIFORNIA AT A GLANCE.

Across 193 California families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 240 193 of 193 families reporting with kids	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$0 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 2 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 52.8% 34.7% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 193	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.2	REPORTING FAMILIES 193 of 193	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 10

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so California families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

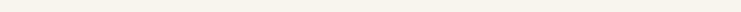
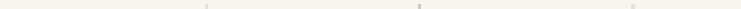
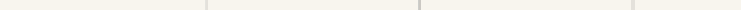
02 THE COST OF CALIFORNIA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	193	\$0	\$54,801	\$10,576,650
Lost Wages	193	\$0	\$84,470	\$16,302,720
Other Court Fees	193	\$0	\$3,617	\$698,000
Therapy / Evaluations	193	\$0	\$4,233	\$816,990
Reunification Services	193	\$0	\$2,206	\$425,770
GAL Fees	193	\$0	\$3,002	\$579,400
Asset Loss ¹	191	\$0	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$0	—	—

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$0) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		2	0.2 yrs
Mean months lost		21	1.8 yrs
Total across all families		3,961	330.1 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · CALIFORNIA

Most families documenting in California are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Unknown		72	37%
Currently involved / "S...		63	33%
Case closed (more tha...		22	11%
Case closed (within th...		21	11%
I am currently stuck in...		10	5%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and ...		70	36%
Family Court Only		61	32%
Unknown		35	18%
CPS (Child Protective ...		25	13%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		41	21%
3 – 5 years		31	16%
5 – 10 years		29	15%
6 months – 1 year		25	13%
Over 10 years		19	10%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Los...		50	26%
Visitation Only		44	23%
50/50 Joint		34	18%
Full Custody		19	10%
Children in Foster Care		18	9%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Unknown		74	38%
Riverside		12	6%
San Diego		12	6%
Los Angeles		8	4%
Ventura		4	2%
Stanislaus		4	2%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Ac...		53	27%
Other: (Short answer)		36	19%
False Accusations CPS...		25	13%
High Conflict Divorce		19	10%
Family Court		15	8%

05 PARENT VOICES — CALIFORNIA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Torn it apart, traumatized my everyday life, I've lost my financial independence, my kids have lost their mother. It has broken trust that I will protect my family when that was ripped from me. I live in fear to conform. My children were also vaccinated with Covid and flu after [...]

— CARMEN

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

This system took my children from me without due process and kept us separated for years based on false allegations and fraud. It destroyed my family, erased irreplaceable years of my children's lives, and caused lasting emotional, financial, and constitutional harm.

— CALIFORNIA PARENT · MORRIS

MORE VOICES FROM CALIFORNIA

Family court system has traumatized my children with lies, false allegations and corruption workers making a paycheck off of the trauma they create.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroy lives and doesn't care about victims and the truth or facts or their children. Greedy attorneys make money and judges filled their pockets

— SALLY

Stripped my 50/50 custody to every other weekend on Saturday to Sunday for 3.5 months under false allegations later found to be unsubstantiated by CPS. Been displaced from my home and a no contact order against my bf even though allegations were proven false.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has become a partner in crime to my kids dad in continuing to abuse me and my children. The system has created a pain inside of my heart that is unbearable. They are torturing and brainwashing my kids to force them to be a part of their false narrative of me being an [...]

— AMARIS

My 12 year old son and I were ripped apart from each other. he was legally kidnapped.

— SABRINA

Blew up the children's lives through 26 court dates. Kids had to rent rooms in other peoples homes to survive the first 3 years.

— KATE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Creating ptsd, depression, my children are being physically emotionally abused, neglected from quality of life and silenced.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed the loving home my son was in and given to sexual abusers and child pornographers.

— REBECCA

The system has allowed my abuser to confine a campaign of coercive control over me and our dishes life for over 2.5 years. Despite repeated warnings and filings of the court letting them know if the ATROS violations, the harm to my employment, and the reality of his neglect and [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The Family Court System Felicitated the No Contact Time in which allowed for the process of Parental Alienation that my ex-wife weaponized against me. This evil corrupted system of Judges playing Gods without any recourse action and Money Hungry attorneys milking their clients [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

CPS overturned the crucial virtues, values, ethics and morals I spent 16 years instilling into my daughters In order for them to have a happy, productive life. Our Family was absolutely destroyed as my children watched the system torture their hero-their mommy.

— LORI

destroyed it completely. Cps refused to let me even have a single visir with them, and tampered with drug tests, told my kids I was dirty when I wasnt , proven by hair test.

— BETH

They have stolen my children's innocence, stability, trust, and sparkle.

— CHERISH

This system has destroyed our lives and the lives of my grandchildren.

— ELIZA

It has ruined my children's life and mine as well. My child has extreme PTSD now and is traumatized. I have lost everything just to fight to keep my children from being harmed . My life will never be the same .

— ASHLEY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Cps has traumatized my children. We were failed and then essentially punished by being separated. My kids were brave and tried to save themselves and were shown the opposite of what they deserved and needed.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Traumatizing devastating situations that could result in mental health issues for my children, myself and financial strain for my family. Retaliation at all time high, when legal avenues are resorted to cure the problem.

— KRESHA

Family court has been profiting off of my family while watching my children's childhoods be destroyed with neglect, abuse, and more heartache than any child should have to endure.

— KELLY

Took full custody of my son for a false allegation and CPS report without any substantial evidence and refuse to give him back and continue to force me and my husband to do parenting/protective parenting for over a year now. No end in sight. Children have confirmed with their [...]

— EMILY

the system has stolen 3 kids from my fiancé and i they have completely destroyed our lives our future our happiness and our dream to start a family of our own.

— CAMERON

Traumatized my children, and I have severe PTSD and anxiety ongoing.

— ANDREA

From the very first city dates, the courts stole my children, allowed my children to be abused, hurt, changed schools, homes. Taken from a loving mother and family. (I never ever kept my children from their father) They caused a loss so great, pain, suffering, illness, not to [...]

— JILLIAN

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Loma Linda children's hospital and CPS fabricated to reports to kidnap our children and force TPR. No one should need to explain the agony, the trauma, the pain this CPS criminal syndicate inflicts on it's victims. These crimes against humanity are domestic terrorism. It must be [...]

— CHRISTINA

I went from having sole legal and physical custody of my children to losing my job, my home, and my children. I have been silenced and left without a voice in the process.

— SARA

Destroyed my family my children brainwashed the trauma my poor innocent child might suffer is terrifying I'm severely PTSD every time I see a county car or cos I survived with my son who I have full custody of longing fighting for my 5 girls to come home

— ANTOINETTE

CFS has ripped me from my children's lives which has caused extreme behaviors that they are attempting to blame me for.

— LATESHA

They have ripped my children away from me, placed them in an abusive harmful environment and sold them to strangers. They have destroyed our family, traumatized and harmed my children and I and slandered my name ruining my reputation so that it is impossible for me to find [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has caused my kids to be brainwashed in thinking I am an abusive mother. This was their father's brainwashing as well.

— ANNABEL

Forced my husband & I to get divorce, and kidnapped our children

— BRANDI

Destroyed mine and my daughter's lives, mental, emotional, and physical health.

— MEGHAN

Imposed unimaginable trauma and financial devastation for my children and I with life long unrecoverable impacts- scorched earth.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Kidnapped my kids and stole my motherhood.tore my family apart and made me mentally unstable

— KAMI

False allegations she has a high price attorney \$500 an hour then they put her attorney fees on me False evidence False witnesses false testimony, I mean it's a regular kangaroo cord over here

— WESLEY

Destroyed my bond with my son I was primary parent it's traumatized my son and has mentally emotionally taken a toll and psychologically maltreatment his dad sabotaged me while he left which created more trauma as I was being harassed as well as my son systematically

— KATIE

Destroyed my children in every aspect, mentally, emotionally. They were never heard, and simply no one cared what my ex did to me in front of them nor do they care how he abused my children in multiple ways.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Judicial corruption, deception and attorney collusion especially in family and probate courts are nothing less than a business. There is a brotherhood among judges that protect the unethical actions. How can you get a fair trial when favoritism and nepotism the driving force [...]

— KEVIN

False allegation was substantiated without due process. Grandchildren removed from us and never seen or heard from again. CPS and the courts have too much power over our families. We need due process if you are going to steal our children from us and cause such harm to all [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Stole my kids from hospital my daughter's (twins) was born on my 1 year recovery date and CPS took them

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Couse me to seperate me from kids and alienated depressed and mentally unstable and the care giver mover further to prevent me to visit them

— ANGEL

The system has destroyed my family and our lives. It has rewarded and protected the criminals and rewarded and protected the abusers and system manipulators.

— ROBERT

134 California parents submitted ranked quotes. 42 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/ca.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT**WHAT THIS IS**

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this California report comes from California respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in California — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 193 California families reporting here are not the universe of California families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics (email + name + submission date) are applied before aggregation. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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